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A New Direction at Google

GOOGLE NEVER FAILS to make news; if not for products, it manages to hit headlines with developments in the technology market. Bob Tedeschi of the *New York Times* asks why Google is now interested in domain names.

AFTER Google disclosed last week that it had been granted the right to sell domain names, the question in many minds was, "Why?" Why would the company, which just reported click-advertising sales of more than \$1 billion (Rs. 43,525,000,000) in the most recent quarter, compete in a relatively low-margin business with Network Solutions, Yahoo!, GoDaddy and others? Would it use its new registrar status to snap up expired domains and show ads to wayward surfers? Is this a move toward Google world domination?

"In a few years, you'll be driving your Google to the Google to buy some Google for your Google," read one posting on Slashdot, an online technology forum.

Eileen Rodriguez, a Google spokeswoman, hardly quelled the speculation by explaining that the whole thing was really a learning opportunity for the company. Google "has become a domain name registrar to learn more about the Internet's domain name system," she said recently in an e-mail. "While we have no plans to register domains at this time, we believe this information can help us increase the quality of our search results."

Ms. Rodriguez would not say how having registrar status might help Google improve search results. But Bret Fausett, who publishes Lertext.com, a Web log following the domain name industry, and who first disclosed the news that Google had become a registrar, said Google could improve the quality of

search results by getting better access to the list of expiring domain names—a list available only to registrars.

When a domain expires and changes hands, Mr. Fausett explained, Google can now more easily find, scan and index the new site, so it does not mistakenly point searchers to a site with irrelevant content, or place advertisers on sites with content that does not match their products or services.

That alone could profoundly affect the domain name market, which has rebounded partly because of another Google

service, AdSense. Through AdSense, Google pays publishers to display text ads related to a site's content. Speculators often buy the expiring domains of even marginally popular Web sites and replace the site's content. But because the practice diminishes the usefulness of Google's search engine, the company has long sought ways to curb it.

Google's continuing refinement of its search technology underscores the intensifying competition in that market, which has carried Internet advertising back to life in recent years. MSN, Yahoo! and others have seen Google parlay popular search technology into a dominant business by selling text advertisements to marketers whenever consumers search for words related to a business.

Read the full report at http://snipurl.com/digit_google

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